combat warfare and always carried anti-cyanide kits. It was the first cyanide death after Rajiv Gandhi's assassination. Radhavinod Raju, on their way back to Madras in an MI-8 chopper, said they should not be surprised if there were more such setbacks.

The Ludlum-like plot continued to thicken. Former top cop of the state Kondath Mohandas went on to write a strong letter to Prime Minister P.V. Narasimha Rao, reiterating his earlier claim of 'intriguing circumstances in which Sriperumbudur was added to Rajiv Gandhi's itinerary' without having consulted the state Congress chief V.K. Ramamurthy. He also underlined the incident of the 'snag in the aircraft from Vizag', which was immediately rectified. These, he claimed, were 'proof of information that the plot had been leaked'. Even as the SIT cited Mohandas's action 'seeking attention', New Delhi could not ignore apprehensions raised by a police officer of his stature and experience. Even before any response could reach him, Mohandas held a press conference in Madras where he repeated his earlier statement to *India Today* about a 'foreign hand' in the assassination. He told the press, 'I strongly suspect some foreign hand behind the assassination. If the LTTE is involved, it is only as a tool.' He also urged the press to look into the warning that had come from Yasser Arafat to Rajiv Gandhi. 'I strongly suspect the LTTE was used as a front for some other organization. Ask Mr Arafat what he had told Rajiv Gandhi about the possibility of Mossad staging a coup in India.'[2]

Unfortunately for Mohandas, his press conference did not elicit the attention he wanted. That Mossad wanted to stage a coup to topple Rajiv Gandhi's government sounded far-fetched. Although there was little evidence of a 'foreign hand' other than the LTTE's, Union Home Minister S.B. Chavan's statement in Parliament about 'certain forces in superpower countries conspiring to kill Rajiv Gandhi' fuelled such speculations further. The US ambassador, in particular, took strong exception to such a claim. The minister later tried to play it down, claiming it was a slip of tongue. But